facilities in its own commercial fleet. China will not follow the West in imposing sanctions on Russia, but it is unlikely to violate them if that exposes its own economic entities to damage. But wherever the risks of retaliation by the US and Europe are manageable, we should expect China to support Russia, both politically and in economic terms.

In the early stages of the war, China vigorously refuted suggestions that what was happening in Ukraine had a parallel in its own situation related to Taiwan, which China claims as its province and reserves the right to use force to unify it with the Chinese mainland. China pointed out that while Ukraine was a sovereign and independent country and a member of the UN, Taiwan was already recognized as being a part of China by a large number of countries and had forfeited its membership of the UN precisely on these grounds in 1971. Therefore, any military move to reunify Taiwan with China would be in the nature of a domestic operation and would not constitute any violation of international law and the UN Charter.

There has been a later twist to this story. On 19 March 2022, Chinese Vice Foreign Minister, Le Yucheng, chose to draw a parallel with the Ukraine war and the situation in the Indo-Pacific region. He said the war in Ukraine was the outcome of the eastward expansion of NATO to encompass the former Warsaw Pact countries and its plans to extend membership to Ukraine, which shares a border with Russia. In the Indo-Pacific there was a similar situation, said Le Yucheng.

> Going against the trend to pursue the Indo-Pacific strategy, promote trouble, put together closed and exclusive small circles and groups, get the region off course towards fragmentation and bloc-based division is as dangerous as the NATO strategy of eastward expansion in Europe. If allowed to go unchecked, it will bring unimaginable consequences and ultimately push the Asia-Pacific over the edge of an abyss . . . The real goal for the Indo-Pacific strategy is to establish an Indo-Pacific version of NATO.[2]

There is an interesting contrast in the US position. While condemning Russian aggression against Ukraine and describing it as a blatant violation